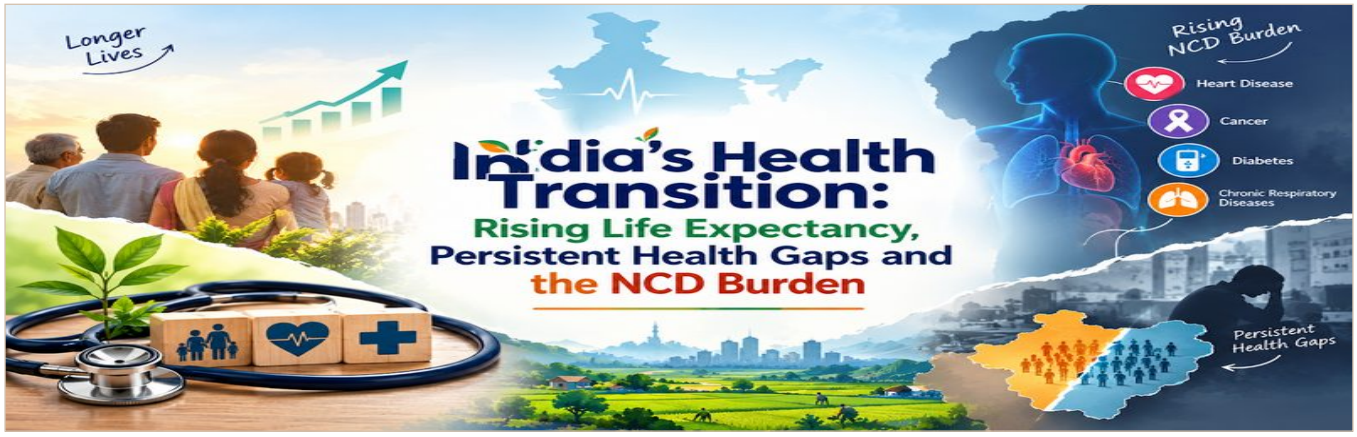


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[GS PAPER I – SOCIETY, GEOGRAPHY • GS PAPER II – SOCIAL JUSTICE, GOVERNANCE • GS PAPER III – ECONOMY, SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY]

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India's Health Transition: Rising Life Expectancy, Persistent Health Gaps and the NCD Burden



India's health profile is undergoing a major transition, marked by rising life expectancy, persistent regional health inequalities and a growing burden of non-communicable diseases. The article examines changes in life expectancy, HALE, disease patterns and India's evolving public-health challenges.

India's Health Transition: Rising Life Expectancy, Persistent Health Gaps and the NCD Burden

Syllabus areas:

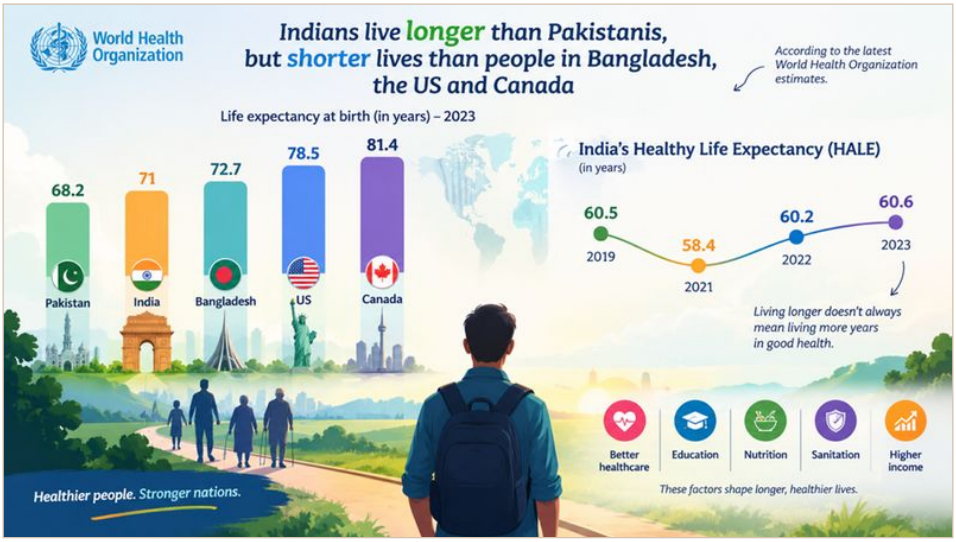
GS Paper I – Society, Geography

GS Paper II – Social Justice, Governance

GS Paper III – Economy, Science & Technology

Indians can expect to live longer than their counterparts in Pakistan, but have shorter lives than people in Bangladesh, the US and Canada, according to the latest **World Health Organization** estimates.

World Health Organization (WHO) is a specialized agency of the United Nations responsible for international public health. Established in 1948, it coordinates global health responses, develops health standards, monitors diseases, and supports countries in strengthening healthcare systems and achieving better health outcomes.

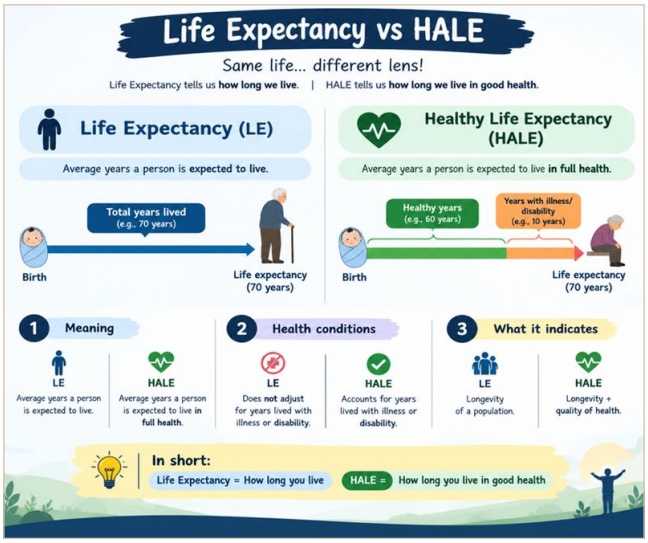


India's **life expectancy at birth** was 71 years in 2023, compared with 68.2 years in Pakistan, 72.7 years in Bangladesh, 78.5 years in the US and 81.4 years in Canada.

Life expectancy at birth is the average number of years a newborn is expected to live, assuming current age-specific mortality rates remain constant. It is a key indicator of population health, healthcare quality, living conditions, and socioeconomic development.

But living longer does not necessarily mean living more years in good health. India's healthy life expectancy (HALE) was 60.6 years in 2023, compared with 60.5 years in 2019. It had fallen to 58.4 years in 2021 before recovering to 60.2 years in 2022.

Healthy Life Expectancy (HALE) is the average number of years a person can expect to live in full health, considering years lived with disease or disability. It measures both longevity and quality of life and is a key global health indicator.



The figures are part of **WHO's Global Health Estimates**, released Friday, covering life expectancy, healthy life expectancy, causes of death and disease burden from 2000 to 2023. WHO said global life expectancy has recovered close to pre-pandemic levels, while healthy life expectancy has recovered more slowly.

WHO's Global Health Estimates (GHE) are comprehensive estimates produced by the World Health Organization on death, disability and major health indicators across the world. They provide data at global, regional and country levels, disaggregated by age, sex and cause.

PATTERN REVERSED

For India, difference is visible over pandemic years: Life expectancy fell from 70.5 years in 2019 to 68.1 in 2021, before rising to 70.5 in 2022 and 71 in 2023

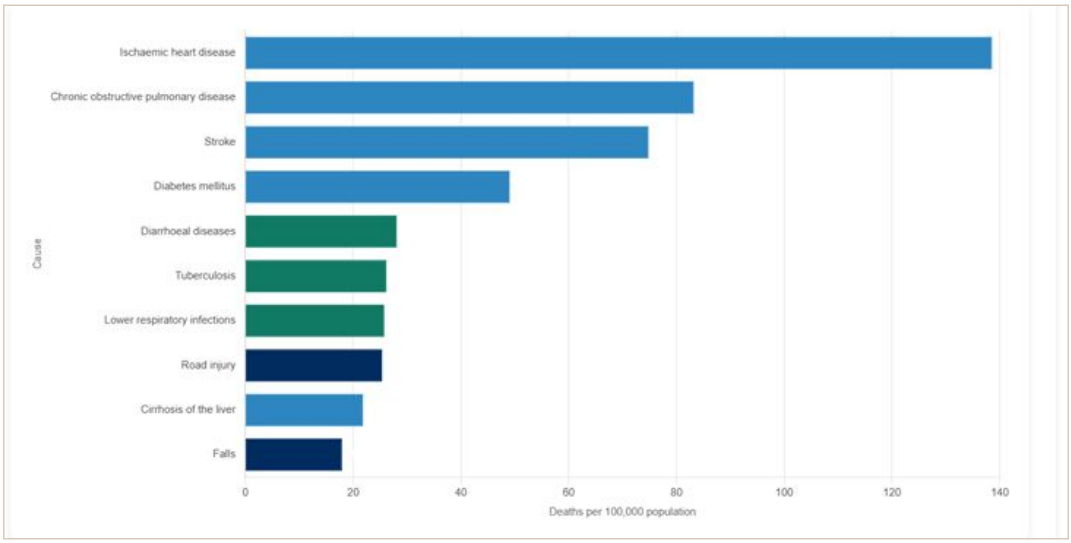
In 2000, communicable diseases accounted for nearly 62% of combined death rate from India's 10 leading causes, while NCDs accounted for 34%. By 2023, pattern reversed, with NCDs accounting for 75% and communicable diseases 16%



Communicable diseases are illnesses caused by infectious agents such as bacteria, viruses, fungi, or parasites that can spread between people, animals, or through contaminated food, water, air, or vectors. Examples include tuberculosis, malaria, dengue, influenza, and COVID-19.

Non-communicable diseases (NCDs) are chronic conditions that generally do not spread from person to person. They include cardiovascular diseases, cancers, diabetes, and chronic respiratory diseases, often associated with genetic, physiological, environmental, and behavioural risk factors and responsible for substantial global mortality.

Top 10 causes of death in India

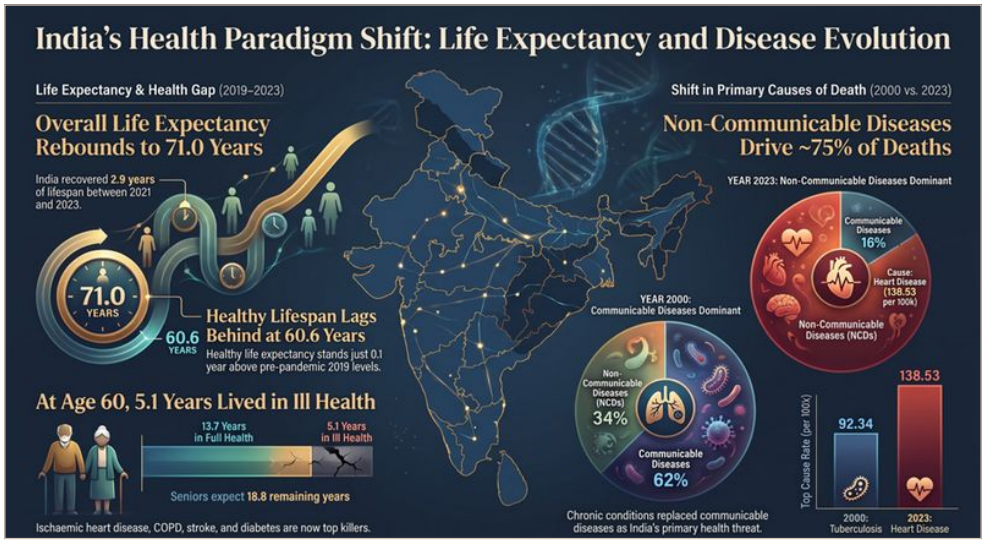


For India, the difference is particularly visible over the pandemic years. Life expectancy fell from 70.5 years in 2019 to 68.1 years in 2021, before rising to 70.5 years in 2022 and 71 years in 2023. In just two years, India regained 2.9 years of expected lifespan.

Healthy life expectancy, however, recovered by only 2.2 years, from 58.4 years in 2021 to 60.6 years in 2023, leaving it just 0.1 year above the 2019 level.

The gap is also visible among older Indians. At age 60, a person could expect another 18.8 years of life in 2023, compared with 18.4 years in 2019. But only 13.7 of those years were expected to be lived in full health, up from 13.4 years in 2019.

India's disease profile has also changed sharply. Communicable diseases, such as tuberculosis and diarrhoeal infections, can spread from person to person, while non-communicable diseases (NCDs), such as heart disease, stroke and diabetes, are generally long-term conditions.



In 2000, communicable diseases accounted for nearly 62% of the combined death rate from the country's 10 leading causes, while NCDs accounted for 34%. By 2023, the pattern had reversed, with NCDs accounting for nearly 75% and communicable diseases 16% of the combined death rate from the top 10 causes. The rest was from injuries.

The shift is evident in the leading causes. In 2000, tuberculosis and diarrhoeal diseases topped the list, with 92.34 and 87.87 deaths per 100,000 population. By 2023, ischaemic heart disease, chronic obstructive pulmonary disease, stroke and diabetes were among the leading causes, with rates of 138.53, 83.19, 74.81 and 49.01 respectively. Yet infectious diseases remain a significant burden, with diarrhoeal diseases, tuberculosis and lower respiratory infections still among India's top 10 causes of death in 2023.

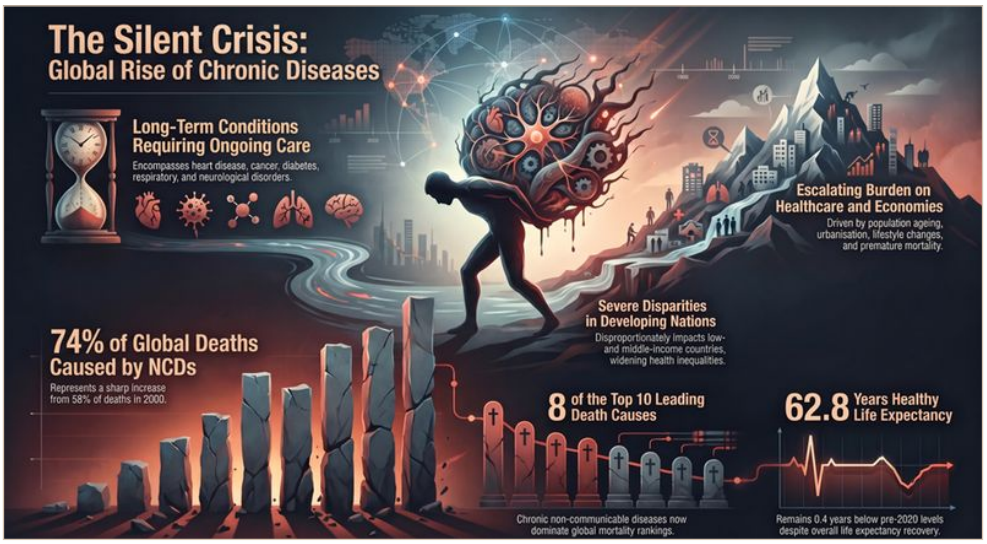
Top 10 causes of death globally:

Rank	Cause of death	Category
1	Ischaemic heart disease	Non-communicable
2	Stroke	Non-communicable
3	Chronic obstructive pulmonary disease (COPD)	Non-communicable
4	Lower respiratory infections	Communicable
5	Alzheimer disease & other dementias	Non-communicable
6	Diabetes mellitus	Non-communicable
7	Trachea, bronchus & lung cancers	Non-communicable
8	Hypertensive heart disease	Non-communicable
9	Kidney diseases	Non-communicable
10	Diarrhoeal diseases	Communicable

Globally, the shift towards **chronic diseases** is also pronounced.

Chronic Diseases

Chronic diseases are long-lasting health conditions that generally develop gradually and require ongoing medical care. They include **heart disease, cancer, diabetes, chronic respiratory diseases, and neurological disorders**, often influenced by ageing, genetics, lifestyle, environmental factors, and socioeconomic conditions.



Chronic diseases are a major global health challenge, causing substantial **premature deaths, disability, healthcare expenditure and productivity losses**. Their burden is increasing with population ageing, urbanisation and changing lifestyles. They disproportionately affect low- and middle-income countries, placing pressure on health systems and widening health inequalities across populations.

NCDs accounted for 74% of deaths in 2023, up from 58% in 2000, while eight of the world's 10 leading causes of death were NCDs. Global life expectancy reached 73.3 years in 2023, almost back to the 73.4 years recorded in 2019, while healthy life expectancy stood at 62.8 years, still 0.4 year below its 2019 level.

Life Expectancy

Life expectancy varies across India, with **southern states generally recording higher life expectancy than several northern states**. States such as Kerala, Tamil Nadu and Karnataka benefit from better healthcare access, female literacy, nutrition and socioeconomic conditions. Some northern states face greater challenges related to maternal and child health, poverty, sanitation and healthcare availability. However, this is a **state-level socioeconomic and health disparity**, not a biological difference between North and South Indians.



State	Life expectancy at birth — Total
Kerala	75.1 years
Tamil Nadu	73.2 years
Karnataka	71.9 years
Andhra Pradesh	70.6 years
Bihar	69.5 years

State	Life expectancy at birth — Total
Uttar Pradesh	~66–67 years

Life expectancy is considerably higher in the **United States than in Africa**. On average, people in Africa live around **64 years**, compared with about **79 years in the USA**, a difference of roughly **15 years**, mainly due to disparities in healthcare, income, nutrition, sanitation, disease burden and living conditions.